The Shelf

User Manual

Your network's stuff, in one place.

A self-hosted media & productivity hub for your home or office network — no cloud, no subscription, nothing leaves the building.

This manual covers setup, every shelf and tool, and account & access controls.

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What The Shelf Is

A little self-hosted hub for your home network. Run it on one computer, and anyone on the same Wi-Fi/network can open it in a browser to look at pictures (with a built-in slideshow), listen to music, watch videos, download a game or program, read a PDF, use the built-in notes, drawing pad, word processor, spreadsheet, and quick-slides tools, and message other people on the network who are running it too — plus a home dashboard with a bulletin board (paste images or video straight onto it) and quick links.

No accounts, no cloud, no internet required for any of that — everything stays on your network. (The one exception is the optional weather reading on the Home tab, which needs this computer to have internet access.)

Getting Started

What you need

- **Node.js** installed on the computer that will host it (the “server”). Download the **LTS** version for your OS and install it like any other program.
  - Windows: download the `.msi` installer and run it.
  - Mac: download the `.pkg` installer and run it.
  - Linux / Raspberry Pi: `sudo apt install nodejs npm` (Debian/Ubuntu/Raspberry Pi OS) or use your distro’s package manager.

That’s the only requirement — the same app works unchanged on Windows, Mac, Linux, and Raspberry Pi.

Setup (do this once)

Easiest way: open the `installer/` folder and double-click the file for your OS — `Install (Windows).bat`, `Install (Mac).command`, or `Install (Linux).sh`. It opens a setup page in your browser where you can pick an install location and choose whether to start The Shelf automatically when your computer starts, then does everything below for you.

Manual way, if you’d rather not use the installer:

- Unzip the project folder somewhere on the host computer, e.g. `Documents/the-shelf`.
- Open a terminal (Command Prompt/PowerShell on Windows, Terminal on Mac/Linux) in that folder.
- Run `npm install` — this downloads the small set of libraries the server uses.

Running it

In the same folder, run:

```
npm start
```

You’ll see something like:

```
The Shelf is up.
On this machine: http://localhost:8080
On your network: http://192.168.1.42:8080
```

- On the host computer itself, open `http://localhost:8080`.
- On any other phone/laptop/TV on the same network, open the “On your network” address shown in your terminal (also shown in the app’s sidebar once it’s running).

Leave the terminal window open — closing it stops the server. To stop it on purpose, click the terminal and press `Ctrl+C`.

Keeping it running in the background (optional)

- **Windows**: minimize the terminal window instead of closing it, or look into `pm2` / Task Scheduler for a more permanent setup.
- **Mac/Linux**: run `nohup npm start &` to keep it running after you close the terminal, or set it up as a `systemd` service / `launchd` agent for something that survives a reboot.
- **Raspberry Pi**: works well as a `systemd` service so it starts automatically on boot.

Everyday Use

Add something

Click “Add something” in the sidebar, pick which shelf it belongs on (Pictures, Music, Videos, Games, Programs, or Books / PDFs), and drag files in or click to choose them. You can also drag files straight from your desktop onto a category in the sidebar to upload directly into it.

Moving files between shelves

Drag any photo, track, or file card onto a different category in the sidebar to move it there. On a phone or tablet (where drag-and-drop between elements doesn’t work), use the small “Move to…” dropdown that appears on every item instead.

Renaming files

Every item on every shelf has a rename control (a tag icon on photos and tracks, a **Rename** button on Games, Programs, and Books / PDFs cards). It prompts for a new name and renames the actual file on the host machine. Leave off the extension and it keeps the original one automatically, so typing just a new title is enough.

Filtering

Every shelf has a “Filter by name” search box, with a small × button that appears once you’ve typed something, to clear it in one tap. Music, Videos, Games, Programs, and Books / PDFs also get a second dropdown to filter by how many times something’s been played, downloaded, or read — never, 1+, 5+, 10+, or 25+ times. Both filters work together at once.

Removing files

Every item on every shelf has a small “×” or “Remove” button that deletes the file from the host computer. It always asks you to confirm first, since this can’t be undone.

The Shelves

Pictures

Shown as a photo grid. Click any photo to open it full-screen, or click **Start slideshow** to auto-advance through them (adjustable seconds-per-photo, arrow keys to skip, Esc to close). The **Fullscreen** button inside the slideshow uses your browser's actual fullscreen mode, hiding the browser chrome entirely.

- Each photo gets a slow **Ken Burns** pan/zoom while it's showing — a checkbox in the slideshow controls turns it off if you'd rather the photos stay still.
- If your Music shelf has anything in it and nothing's already playing, starting the slideshow shuffles through your music as background audio automatically.
- Click the pencil icon on a photo to open the **editor**: rotate, flip, and adjust brightness/contrast/saturation, then **Save** or **Save as copy**.

Music

Click a track to play it; a mini player appears at the bottom with its album art (if it has any), play/pause, a seek bar, a small live visualizer, and a volume slider. Double-click the visualizer to blow it up to a real fullscreen view, with six different visualization styles — bars, a mirrored waveform, a radial burst, a spinning kaleidoscope, a field of colored shapes, and a classic green oscilloscope trace — click anywhere to cycle through them, with a slider to dial the color anywhere between orange and green.

- A **Get album art** button looks up cover art for tracks that don't have it yet (searched by filename, via Apple's iTunes catalog) and shows it as a thumbnail; tap or hover to see it full-size. A **Clear album art** button resets it.
- When a track finishes, the next one starts automatically; it stops after the last track rather than looping.

Videos

Click one to play it in a small floating player that stays put while you keep browsing. A **Get thumbnails** button grabs a real frame from each video that doesn't have one yet — entirely in your browser, no extra software needed — shown as a thumbnail next to each video. A **Clear thumbnails** button resets it.

Standardizing messy filenames

Both Music and Videos have a **Standardize names** button in the header — handy since files downloaded from other sites often come with messy names like `YTDown.com_YouTube_Song-Name_Media_abc123xyz09_001_1080p.mp4`. It cleans those up to just `Song Name.mp4`, renaming the actual files on the host computer. Names that already look normal are left alone.

Games & Programs

Shown as cards with a **Download** button. If a game is a single `.html` file, or a `.zip` containing an HTML5 game, a **Play** button appears — click it to run the game in a new browser tab, no download needed.

- Since browsers can only upload individual files, zip up a game's folder before adding it if it has more than one file.
- Games show a play count; Programs show a **download** count instead, since there's no way to know if a downloaded program actually got run.
- A small info button next to the heading shows a short write-up of what The Shelf is — handy if you're introducing it to someone new.

Books / PDFs

For PDFs — manuals, ebooks, scanned documents, whatever. Shown as cards with a **Read** button that opens the PDF right in the app, using the browser's own built-in PDF viewer, rather than forcing a download first. Shows how many times something's been read, and works with the same filtering, renaming, and moving as every other shelf.

The Tools

Below the shelves, there's a second group of tabs for quick everyday tools. Everything here saves automatically as you type — there's no separate save button to remember, except the draw pad, which has its own Save so you control when a drawing is kept.

Home

A quick dashboard: a new affirmation and color of the day automatically every day, a quick weather reading for wherever you're browsing from, the date/time, shelf counts at a glance, a bulletin board you can pin notes to, a quick-links list, and a Backup & restore section. Paste an image or video (Ctrl+V) anywhere on this tab and it's pinned straight to the board.

- **Weather is the one part of this app that needs internet access.** If you say no to the location prompt, or the computer has no internet, the weather reading just quietly doesn't appear — everything else works the same either way.

Notes

A simple list of notes with a title and a text body. Click **+ New note** to start one. Paste an image (Ctrl+V) while typing and it's attached as a thumbnail.

Draw

A tabbed drawing pad. Each tab is a separate drawing. Pick a color, adjust brush size, use the eraser, undo, or clear the canvas, then click **Save**. Unsaved strokes are saved automatically if you switch away.

- **Text**: click the Text button, click the canvas to type a label, drag the handle to reposition, press Enter to stamp it.
- **Shapes**: Rect, Circle, and Line draw from click to release, with a live preview.
- **Copy** copies the drawing to your clipboard as an image (needs `localhost`, not the network address).
- **Paste** puts an image from your clipboard onto the canvas, scaled to fit and centered — counts as a normal action, so Undo removes it.

Docs

A basic word processor — bold/italic/underline, headings, bullet/numbered lists, and a text size slider. Paste an image (Ctrl+V) and it's inserted inline.

Sheets

A mini spreadsheet. Click a cell to type a value or a formula starting with `=` — supports `=SUM(A1:A5)`, `=AVERAGE(A1:B4)`, and simple totals like `=A1+A2+3`.

- **Import**: drag a `.csv`, `.tsv`, `.xls`, `.xlsx`, or `.ods` file onto the tab to bring it in as a new sheet.

Slides

Build a quick slide deck (a heading + body text per slide), then click **Present** to show it full-screen. Arrow keys move between slides, Esc exits. Paste an image while editing a slide and it’s attached to that slide.

Messages

Chat with other computers running The Shelf on the same network — it finds them automatically, no setup, no adding contacts. Set your display name and a status at the top; anyone else running The Shelf shows up under “Online now.” Messages go directly between the two computers — nothing passes through the internet or any third party — and only work while both computers are on.

- This relies on network broadcast, so it only finds other installs on the **same local network segment**. It won’t find installs across different networks, VPNs, or guest Wi-Fi that isolates devices.

Visitors

A plain list of devices that have loaded this Shelf — name (or IP address) and when they were first and last seen. This tracks anyone who’s opened the app in a browser at all, not just other Shelf installs. Visiting from `localhost` doesn’t count. A **Clear all** button is available if you’d rather not keep this history.

Accounts & Access Control

By default (“Anonymous read only”), anyone on your network can open The Shelf and browse everything, but only the machine actually running The Shelf can make changes. Anyone connecting from another device is read-only until you set up an account for them. There are two independent settings, both host-only:

Accounts

A gear icon next to the “Anonymous read only” / “Secured visitors” toggle opens a small panel where you create named logins, each either **Can make changes** or **Read only**. Anyone connecting from another device has to log in with a write-access account to upload, delete, rename, or edit anything — browsing still stays open to everyone. Passwords are hashed, never stored in plain text, and this machine itself always has full access without logging in.

Secured visitors mode

The toggle right next to the power switch goes a step further: switch it to **Secured visitors** and even *browsing* requires a login — the whole Shelf is invisible to anyone who isn’t logged in from another device.

Sessions are kept in memory only, not written to disk, so restarting The Shelf logs everyone out.

***A note on what this is (and isn’t) protecting against**: this is meant to stop casual mistakes and unwanted changes from people on your home or office network, not to withstand a determined attacker. The Shelf runs over plain HTTP (no certificate is set up), so avoid using a password here that you use anywhere important.*

Turning the whole thing off

At the top of the sidebar there’s a toggle labeled “The Shelf is on.” Switching it off turns off the whole app for everyone on your network — anyone who visits sees a simple “turned off” page instead. The app itself keeps running quietly in the background, so switching it back on works instantly — no restart needed.

Backup & restore

On the Home tab there’s a **Backup & restore** section. **Export a backup** downloads a single `.zip` with everything — your shared files, notes, drawings, sheets, presentations, and messages. **Import a backup** on a fresh install brings everything back. Importing **replaces** everything currently on that install, so it asks you to confirm first.

Tips & Troubleshooting

Changing the port

By default it runs on port `8080`. If that's already in use, run it on a different port instead:

```
# Mac/Linux
PORT=9000 npm start

# Windows (PowerShell)
$env:PORT=9000; npm start
```

The Messages tool also uses a fixed network port (`41234`, UDP) to find other installs — this isn't currently configurable.

About the installer

The installer is a small Node script with a real settings page — not a compiled app, since building those properly requires platform-specific tools. It copies the app to your chosen location (leaving your own files/notes/drawings untouched on a reinstall), optionally sets up autostart, and starts the app right away.

- **If it seems stuck on "Installing…"**: the file-copy step can genuinely take a minute or two on Windows if antivirus software scans each file. The terminal window behind the setup page shows live progress.
- **If you're re-running the installer to upgrade**: it checks whether an old copy is still running on the port it needs and safely closes it first.
- **If the page shows "Failed to fetch"**: the setup process itself stopped running mid-install — check the terminal window behind the page for what happened.

That's everything — enjoy The Shelf.